

Product Manager - Interview Plan

We need to have high confidence in the following:

- Great English written/verbal communication
- Ability to overlap with 9 to 11am PST, 2 to 3 times a week
- A few years of experience in working directly with a development team as a product manager, project manager, or program manager
 - Has lead agile development rituals (stand-ups, sprint planning, refinement)
- Ability to deeply understand product needs / requirements and has worked with a development team to translate those requirements into clear implementation plans / timelines
 - Has the ability to work closely with engineering counterparts to make implementation decisions through working through tradeoffs

Nice to have:

- Well-versed in making data-driven decisions
- Has run experiments and a/b tests
- Experience working on direct-to-consumer products

Interview plan

Hiring Manager - Amit (I think the plan is for John to be the manager though)

Resume Screen - Amit

Initial Screen 1 - Qrata (30 min) - add additional questions

- Validate that the candidate has several years of experience in working as a product manager, project manager, program manager with a development team
- Validate that the candidate knows how to run agile rituals and planning

Screen 2 - Shilanjani (30 min)

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1st Round - Amit (60 min)

- General introductions
- **Project Management:** I would like to understand your ability to manage a project from inception to launch. Can you walk me through a recent feature or project you lead from idea through launch. I am specifically looking to understand what your process looked

like, who did you collaborate with, and what the touch points look like with the development team building the feature (10 minutes)

- **Collaboration & Decision Making:** Can you describe a time when you had to work closely with engineering to refine a set of requirements based on feedback from your engineering team? What was your approach, and how did you ensure the final requirements met user needs while considering implementation complexities? (10 min)
- **Problem Solving:** I'm interested in understanding your approach to solving problems. Say I came to you and said we need to figure out how to increase retention. How would you approach this?

2nd Round - John (60 min)

Assess:

- Culture fit with the rest of the team
 - Can empathize with developers
 - Willingness to listen and collaborate with the team
 - Humble and easily approachable
- Motivation to join Lumos Labs
- Alignment of Future expectations / goals
- Eye for detail
 - Capacity to absorb and distill various requirements and conversations
- Thoroughness with execution
 - Has the patience to tie all loose ends together by diligently collaborating with all stakeholders
- High level understanding of technical terminology / concepts (APIs, Databases, Datawarehousing, Microservices etc)
- Understand the work done / impact created in the Indian context if they happen to come from Indian startup ecosystem.

Questions:

- Dive into 2-3 examples from their resume and ask them to walk you through in detail what the product - engineering collaboration looks like:
 - How do they work with engineering on the handoff between requirements to creating implementation plans?
 - When given feedback from engineering partners that the dev cost / scope is high for a specific initiative or set of requirements, what do they do in those situation?

3rd Round - Bob (60 min)

Assess: I would use this interview to assess their intellectual ceiling. They may not have the specific experience required for a D2C PM, at the same time we should get a signal on:

- Their ability to approach novel problems
- Can they intelligently ask questions about data/metrics?
- Are they user-centric?
- Can they think about 2nd order effects such as tradeoffs between metrics? (ex. Conversion rate vs. retention rate)

Suggestion Questions:

- Ask the candidate how they would approach the problem of improving a specific metric such as retention, monetization, engagement?
 - Do they have a framework for approaching problems?
 - Are they able to distill the problem down?
 - Do they have an intuition for metrics / sub-metrics they would want to test?
 - Use the candidates response to pose an experiment they could consider running:
 - Do they talk about what their hypothesis is?
 - How would they setup an experiment to test their hypothesis?
 - How they would determine success?
 - What happens if their target metric improves at the expense of another important metric? (ex. conversion rate vs retention rate)
- Some candidates reference certain metrics they improved in their resume, you could hone into one or two of these and deep dive into these points.

Notes to review

What to assess

Experience:

- Project Management:
 - Has experience in working closely with stakeholders to facilitate decisions and define requirements.

- Understands how to take requirements and collaborate with engineering to refine requirements with input
- Has experience in managing sprints - refining the backlog, writing stories, assigning stories to engineers, managing progress against the stories, leading rituals

Attributes:

- Bias for action:
 - Does the candidate take action when faced with an obstacle or ambiguous situation?
 - When they are blocked or perceive they have blockers, does the candidate have novel ways to continue to make progress and / or unblock themselves?
 - Is the candidate able to break a problem down to identify which pieces they can continue to make progress on while waiting for information on other pieces? Do they formulate a plan in these situations?
- Communication: The candidate must have stellar written and verbal communication
 - Communication must be succinct and clear
- Growth Mindset: We may not find a candidate with direct to consumer experience. For this reason, it is important this person has a strong demonstrated interest in learning new skills
 - When faced with a knowledge gap, does the candidate proactively fill that gap?
- Problem Solving: Does the candidate have a framework for problem solving?
 - Do they know how to break problems down?
 - Do they separate assumptions from facts?
 - Do they ask clarifying questions?
 - Do they consider 2nd / 3rd order effects?
 - Do they clearly define who is going to be impacted by the problem?
- High Intellectual Ceiling: We need to validate that the candidate has a high ceiling and can learn and grow with minimal hand holding

Flexibility:

- Timezone: Can the candidate overlap with US Pacific Standard Time 9 to 10am PST at least 3x / week?

45 minute intro session

- General introductions

- **Project Management:** I would like to understand your ability to manage a project from inception to launch. I am specifically looking to understand what your process looks like, who you collaborate with, and what the touch points look like with the development team building the feature (10 minutes)
- **Problem Solving:** I'm interested in understanding your approach to solving problems. Say I came to you and said we need to figure out how to reduce churn - the % of subscribers who's subscription expired in any given period. Give me a sense of how you would approach this problem?
- **Collaboration & Decision Making:** Can you describe a time when you had to refine a set of requirements based on feedback from your engineering team? What was your approach, and how did you ensure the final requirements met user needs while considering implementation complexities? (10 min)

Review: <https://chatgpt.com/share/bc8d79c0-d88c-44c8-9387-f6010fac9f53>